

THE BRIEF

AUDIENCE
Philanthropy & foundational-skills grant funders

FRAMING
Grant-seeking · capability guarantee, not remediation

THE REFRAME
A degree that durably lifts the skills the labor market pays for

THE ASK
Fund validated foundational-skills pedagogy, folded into the degree & measured

KEY SIGNALS

~+28%
Wages per SD of numeracy · U.S. PIAAC

~62%
Service workers w/ limited literacy · AIR

~74%
Service workers w/ limited numeracy · AIR

~38%
Adults at numeracy Level 3+ · PIAAC 2023

THREADS

- Science of Reading
- Embedded Numeracy
- PIAAC
- Economic Mobility
- Measured Gains

Figures came from web snippets and are flagged for verification against primary sources (PIAAC/ NCES, Hanushek et al.) before presenting.

The labor market pays for the skill — not just the diploma.

Literacy and numeracy independently predict wages and promotions, even controlling for degrees, experience, and demographics. Yet most working adults sit below proficiency, and a credential can be earned without the basics improving. This strategy folds validated foundational-skills pedagogy into the Apprenticeship Degree — and measures the gain — so the degree doesn't just certify, it durably lifts earnings.

The skills are independently priced. A sizable earnings premium per standard deviation of numeracy/ literacy, robust to controls for education (Hanushek et al., 2015).

- Most working adults are below the line — concentrated in exactly the frontline and service-sector workers the Apprenticeship Degree serves.
- Credential ≠ capability. Without explicit, measured instruction, the gain is assumed, not assured. We assure it with pre/post measurement.

01 THE QUIET CEILING

A quiet ceiling caps adult mobility — the two skills underneath every promotion: **literacy and numeracy**. A degree can lift the credential without lifting the ceiling unless the foundational skills move too. Decades of PIAAC evidence show the skill itself is paid for, net of the diploma.

02 THE GAP

- ~38% of U.S. adults reach numeracy Level 3+ — a majority below (PIAAC 2023).
- ~62% / 74% of service workers limited in literacy / numeracy (AIR).
- OECD's latest survey flagged a **decline**, not gains.

03 THE PEDAGOGY IS READY

The **science of reading** — the evidence base that reshaped K-12 literacy — is now reaching adult education (ProLiteracy). **Contextualized, embedded numeracy** outperforms decontextualized drill (IES). Both slot into a degree that already teaches **in the flow of work**.

04 ASSURE THE GAIN

The differentiator is **assurance**: pre/post assessment (PIAAC-aligned) so every cohort's gain is visible. That turns the strategy into a fundable, evaluable program — a skill-movement metric sitting upstream of the mobility metric (wage / promotion).

“...integrating foundational literacy, numeracy and digital skills directly into workforce training rather than treating them as separate requirements.”

— Lumina Foundation, "A fragile foundation: The skills gaps holding adults back," 2026 — a major funder's framing seconds this strategy.

CAPABILITY GUARANTEE

Fund the assurance that an Apprenticeship Degree graduate leaves **measurably stronger** in the two skills most tightly linked to lifetime earnings. **Measured gains turn a degree into a capability guarantee** — locking in income and promotion gains and making them real rather than nominal, for the workers most affected.

Sources: Hanushek, Schwerdt, Wiederhold & Woessmann (2015), "Returns to skills around the world: Evidence from PIAAC" • NCES, "PIAAC Highlights of U.S. National Results" (2023) • AIR, "Do U.S. Adults Have the Skills Needed to Thrive?" • ProLiteracy, "The Science of Reading... in Adult Education" • IES/NCEE, "Adult Education Strategies" • Lumina Foundation (2026) — draft narrative; figures pending verification.